

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Andrew Fellows

Address: 24 Balmoral Way Sutton SM2 6PD

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am resubmitting my objection with a 2nd version after the Council only today put up notices near the application site to give residents time to comment. I wish to formally object to the above planning application, given the events of the last few days, the clear signal that there is a race to submit supporting and objecting comments on the Council website and the fact that local residents are not being consulted in full. I do support the provision of facilities for the entire community in Sutton and Belmont but it is clear this proposal fails to meet those requirements, such as those as set out in the community cohesion and social integration stipulations, set out in the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) dated December 2024 and supported by the findings of the 2016 Casey Review which holds precedence here. This application is for the benefit of one faith group only, not for the wider Belmont community and certainly not for residents of Dorset Road, Avenue Road, York Road, Holland Avenue, Belmont High Street, Belmont Road, Queens Avenue, Kings' Road, Cross Road and Balmoral Way who will all suffer from both increased vehicular traffic in the area, as well as increased usage of currently inadequate public transport (whether bus or train), should the application succeed. Many objectors have pointed out, as do I, that is not a question of NIMBYS (Not in my backyard) and/or house price or other societal concerns to be absolutely clear, but a question of what happens to a quiet residential area which is already over-stretched in terms of infrastructure and overstretched in terms of transportation flows and unacceptable parking, as recognised by the Council. Also, we have not been informed in any way, until the Council put up two notices on lampposts which are easily overlooked, today 23rd February 2026, of what was being planned and only have 21 days to object. This time is

insufficient given the thoroughness with which the applications has not only sought professional advice, but also received pre-application feedback from the Council. It seems the residents of Belmont do not matter and will not be given sufficient time to respond. I would further state that, should the Council approve the application, it would represent a failure to meet the NPPF (2024) Requirements for Social Interaction. Under Paragraph 96(a) of the NPPF (Dec 2024), planning decisions must aim to achieve healthy, inclusive, and safe places that "promote social interaction, including opportunities for meetings

between people who might not otherwise come into contact with each other," this means people of all faiths, not just one. The current proposal is designed as a specialized, single-use, single-faith facility. By its nature and the planned scale, the facility does not facilitate the broad spectrum of social mixing and interaction, as required by the Framework cited above and will not do so. The planning application, when one reads the detail, also refers to visitors being welcome and groups of up to 250, (I assume it will be more than this!), being present for Friday prayers and for special events. The number of parking spaces available for that group is woefully low. Furthermore, I request the Council to note that, instead of creating a "shared space," a successful application risks creating a "closed space." The NPPF's Paragraph 98 requires that planning for shared spaces must benefit "all sections of the community." Given that this proposal serves a narrow demographic, it fails the "all sections" test of the NPPF in totality.

2. There is an even greater risk of Social Segregation (The Casey Review). The Casey Review (2016), which remains a cornerstone of UK integration policy, warns explicitly against the formation of "parallel lives" or ghettos. The Review highlights how concentrated faith facilities can accelerate residential clustering and reduce everyday mixing between different ethnic and religious groups. The proposed development, due to its [size/intensity of use], risks consolidating a single faith-based enclave with ever larger numbers driving to it in this entirely residential part of Belmont and Sutton. This directly contradicts the Borough's duty and legal responsibility, in my view, to foster a cohesive community where residents from different backgrounds interact regularly and to preserve residential environments. The Casey Review also argues that integration is a "two-way street"; this proposal, however, represents a "one-way" use of land that offers little to the wider non-aligned community or other religious groups in the area.

3. Disproportionality Relative to Local Need (2021 Census)

According to the 2021 Census data for Sutton, the religious landscape of the borough is highly diverse, which I welcome being married to someone who is of another ethnic group, but also significantly secular, (unfortunately in my view!):

Christian: 45.8%

No Religion: 32.3%

Muslim: 7.0%, (Belmont in 2021 was 9.43% only in the specific ward)

Hindu: 7.0%

With nearly one-third, (32.3%) of Sutton's population identifying as having "no Religion," and other groups such as the Hindu community being underserved, there is a demonstrable and greater strategic need for neutral, secular community spaces that serve the entire population of the Belmont ward and the London Borough of Sutton, if one were to grant such applications. Granting

a large-scale, single-faith facility for a demographic representing 7% of the borough/9.43% of the Belmont ward admittedly is totally disproportionate, especially if that facility does not provide significant, guaranteed access for the 93% of residents who do not share that faith or have another faith to use that local facility. In addition there are already faith/worship places (6 in total) available in the borough of Sutton, representing more than adequate provision for the 7%, as well as further large-scale provision in Morden. The proposal in its current form undermines the "Cohesion" mandate of the NPPF 2024 and ignores the integration warnings of the Casey Review. It fails to reflect the actual demographic needs of Sutton as evidenced by the 2021 Census. On this basis alone, the application should be rejected. However, my main point is not around integration but parking and traffic and woeful infrastructure in the London Borough of Sutton and in Belmont particularly, a mere few miles or km from the centre of our capital city.

5. Problems with Traffic and Parking and Infrastructure. Furthermore, the traffic flow, the parking situation from drop-off and pick-ups from the Avenue Primary Academy, (for which we have evidence of today only and are collecting further evidence), demonstrates clearly double-parking, parking on double yellow lines, parking in front of people's driveways, traffic chaos, and the inherent danger to schoolchildren being brought to and from school. Clearly, the school children and their parents cannot take responsibility for the traffic situation and they cannot find parking elsewhere to bring their (often young) children to school, and these children in today's time cannot walk to school alone, it is far too dangerous. To then impose further traffic and potential danger to those children is quite frankly unacceptable and the Council would not be fulfilling its duty to all residents of Sutton and to those schoolchildren, if the traffic, traffic flow, parking situation, lack of adequate infrastructure in Belmont and Sutton, lack of controlled parking zones, (which we should have in this area and for which I intend to apply), and inadequate consideration of resident's wishes are simply ignored. The assertions made in the application have not been tested, in respect of surveys of parking done at midnight, and only on one Friday, this is frankly insufficient, and it would be remiss, if not to say negligent, of the Council not to conduct its own independent, impact survey on parking, traffic flows, effects on the already overstretched situation with Avenue Primary parents' parking at drop-off and pick-up times, examining the situation at those times, (for which I have taken 67 photos today alone), and the wishes of the majority of local residents, (that is those in Dorset Road and the roads adjoining Dorset Road), many of whose children walk to school to have safe, undisturbed access for their children, as well as the desire of residents for peace and quiet. This is why we moved here. We already face a chaotic situation in terms of traffic flow at such times and the Council should not permit this to get worse.

6. The Environmental Health Protection Act of 1990 also requires the Council to protect the health of residents of the Borough and its wards and illegal, inconsiderate and disrespectful parking, as witnessed today during school drop-offs and pick-ups, (which is no fault of the Avenue Primary and its parents), already stretch the tolerance and our physical infrastructure, (which is outdated) to its maximum.

7. I would request the Council, in addition to the requests above, to carry out an environmental impact assessment before any planning application is approved to look at the effects of Friday prayers, weekly prayers, late-night sessions, blocked driveways, double and illegal parking and the potential effects of overloading the locality which already suffers from an intolerable parking

and traffic situation. The local area simply cannot handle the planned number - and I believe this is a low estimate - number of worshippers which might be expected and the effect on the roads listed above will be totally unacceptable, given we know what 'overloading' looks like from the lack of infrastructure, (road parking and access), for the Avenue School alone.

8. This planning application will make a bad situation worse for all in the Borough and I request the Council planning committee to reject the application in its entirety and to order relevant investigations into the traffic, parking and environmental impacts, should the Council have doubts.